

## **\*\*The Smartphone Society and Those Three Giants in Power\*\***

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There is a common element in the hundreds of millions of photos – perhaps billions – shared on social media during New Year's Eve: whether by the sea or in the snow, in Beijing or New York, in Iceland or South Africa, in the center of a metropolis or in the square of a small village in Provence, everywhere the light from smartphone screens has taken center stage. Around the world, we welcomed the New Year with a smartphone in hand, just as we do for every celebration, event, show, social occasion, or religious ceremony, including funerals. These photos symbolize the “smartphone society” in which we live. Moreover, there are over 7.5 billion smartphones in circulation for a global population of 8 billion people. Excluding children and those still using old-generation mobile phones, this means more than one smartphone per person. In Italy, there are just under 50 million smartphones for a population that does not reach 60 million, including children.

Whether it is taking a photograph, scanning a QR code to access any kind of online content, searching for car keys in a bag, finding our way while driving or walking, sending a message, ordering food for delivery, booking a trip, browsing social media, displaying a ticket for a show or a museum, or a boarding pass, or paying in contactless mode, it is the smartphone that we rush to grab. And it doesn't stop there, because the smartphone has also become the most sought-after babysitter in the world for our children, our tireless secretary, our portable office, our most trusted advisor in helping us find a soulmate, our family doctor, the grandmother we ask for the recipe for the cake. And we are just at the beginning. The smartphone is progressively replacing our identity documents, our credit cards, our house and car keys, and is becoming the universal remote through which we control and will control everything around us: the lights, the appliances, and the security systems of our homes, our car.

This is true worldwide. And it is not just a matter of the number of devices in circulation but also, and above all, the space they occupy in our daily lives: a quarter of global smartphone owners, or just under two billion people, use it for over seven hours a day, while one-fifth, about one and a half billion people, for over five hours, and one-third, over two billion people, between three and five hours. We are facing a unique phenomenon in the history of humanity: never has a tool been so present in the lives of so many people around the world. It is no surprise, then, that according to a survey a few months ago by Swg, two out of five Italians suffer from “nomophobia” - NO Mobile Phone PhoBIA - the fear of being disconnected, away from their smartphone. Without the smartphone, we literally feel lost.

This phenomenon suggests some reflections. The first: a couple of companies, three at most, firmly control the global smartphone market and, therefore, in one way or another, our lives and those of the states in which we live. They are Apple and Samsung, the undisputed leaders in the production and marketing of devices, and Google, the producer of Android, the operating system for almost all smartphones other than those produced by Apple, including Samsung. It is difficult to imagine another market so relevant in people's lives and society, characterized by a similar oligopolistic condition. Two American giants and one Korean play a key role in our lives. Even in geopolitical terms, this is no small matter. An immense concentration of power leads to the second reflection. Personal data and confidential information of seven and a half billion people and hundreds of governments pass through electronic devices controlled by three digital superpowers. Our fate and that of the entire world is literally in their hands, at least in the technological dimension.

It is the smartphone, now, that says good morning to us in the morning and good night in the evening, that knows when we wake up and when we go to sleep, what we do during the day, with whom we spend our time, how much we dedicate to chatting with friends, how much to working, how much to organizing our vacations, how much in motion and how much sitting, and it is the smartphone that takes care of our diet, our physical activity, our sleep cycle, and tracks women's fertility periods, and it is always the smartphone that manages our payments and our finances, that knows when we leave and when we are home, who our friends are and how often we meet them, and it is always the smartphone that holds our biometric data, the most precious of all, those unique to our face, our eyes, our fingerprints, our voice. Our life is literally in our smartphone, and a handful of commercial

companies are its absolute guardians.

Even governments, judges, and authorities need the authorization of the smartphone market lords to access it if necessary for combating crime, as suggested by some old and new judicial cases around the world. If it is true, as it is true, that information is power, there is no one who has more power than the producers of smartphones and...

of their operating systems. Then there are the rules, those regarding privacy, those concerning the confidentiality of electronic communications, those related to state secrets, those that govern the enforcement of rights by judges, authorities, and law enforcement agencies, and, of course, those that regulate markets and competition, which limit risks and potential abuses of this power; that is another matter. These rules are essential to ensure the democratic sustainability of the smartphone society. Without them, we would probably be literally puppets controlled through our smartphones. And it is difficult to deny that, to some extent, it is already so.

We arrive at the third and final reflection: the smartphone society has literally put the world in our hands and has offered us unimaginable opportunities. But, at the same time, it has compressed individuals' rights to self-determination, competition in markets, and the autonomy of governments. The globalizing and homogenizing power of human behavior through smartphones is enormous, greater than that of any other technological device, and it exerts its effects indiscriminately in personal, professional, economic, cultural, social, and democratic dimensions.

Smartphones are monopolizing our lives; their manufacturers are colonizing hundreds of markets and influencing the actions of hundreds of governments. Watches, by now, are either connected to smartphones or are mere fashion accessories because time, worldwide, is kept by smartphones. The satellite navigators in our cars are progressively becoming useless trinkets because almost all of us trust more the two or three that dominate our smartphones. Sales of cameras have literally collapsed because, by now, photos are taken with smartphones. The same fate has befallen camcorders, calculators, portable translation devices, videoconferencing systems, home landline phones, portable gaming consoles, and digital music players. Either a service is available on our smartphone, or it simply does not exist, much like online content that is not indexed by Google. It is Apple, Google, and Samsung that decide which digital services thrive on smartphones and which do not.

Google itself knows this well; in order to ensure that owners of Samsung smartphones found its search engine pre-installed and the icon to access its Play Store, it recently paid the latter over 8 billion dollars. Even big tech companies, in the smartphone society, sometimes suffer or, at least, feel the consequences of the absence of competition. The same happens to governments along the path of digitalizing administration. Engaging and making agreements with Apple, Samsung, and Google has become essential if one wants to provide digital services to citizens in a manner that is, as we say today, mobile first.

Just think of digital citizenship apps like our IO, the Green Pass, and the contact tracing apps from the dark days of the pandemic, but also apps for tax payments or for recognizing bonuses and incentives, the lottery for receipts, services for booking medical examinations, and telemedicine apps. The state, in short, now must go through smartphones to manage public affairs and guarantee citizens their rights. Whether we care about our freedom, competition, our children's education, or democracy, it is the smartphone market that we should be most concerned about.